MODULE 2

Module 2: Fades

12 techniques · 36 video lessons



THE BARBER ACADEMY

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Next step

> *A fade is a haircut where the hair gradually shortens from longer on top to very short, or even skin-level, at the bottom, with no visible line between the two. It is the most requested men's cut in most shops and the skill that clients judge a barber by. This module teaches it one clear step at a time.*

What you will learn in Module 2

You will start with the vocabulary: the three fade tones (dark, medium and light), the recession lines that show where the hair stops and the skin begins, and the head landmarks you will use as height markers. Then you will work through the low, mid, high and skin fades, the taper fade, the lever and clipper-over-comb blending methods, the Clean Fade that removes every blend mark, and the detail work around the ear and neckline. The last lesson is a troubleshooting guide for lines, patches and uneven sides.

How to use the lessons

1. Read the whole lesson once before you pick up a tool.
2. Watch the matching curated video lessons from experienced barbers, then come back and follow the written steps slowly.
3. Practice on a mannequin head or a practice mannequin with real hair first. Move to a live head only when your blends are consistent and your hands are steady.
4. Finish every lesson by checking your work with the mistakes list, then repeat the practice drill.

Guard numbers used in this module

GUARD	APPROX. LENGTH	TYPICAL USE
#0	1/16 in	Skin or near-skin base, first blend
#1	1/8 in	Short base, dark-to-medium transitions
#2	1/4 in	Middle of most fades
#3	3/8 in	Upper transition into longer hair
#4	1/2 in	Top of the fade, taper sides

Guard sizing can vary slightly between manufacturers, so always check the length printed on your guard or measure it before you start. Where a lesson says 'open the lever', it means moving the adjustable blade of the clipper to a slightly longer setting, and 'closed' means the shortest setting.

Safety and licensing first

Sanitize your hands and tools before every client, use clean blades, and keep a fresh neck strip and cape in place. In many places you need a barber or cosmetology license to cut hair for pay, so check your local licensing requirements. The certificate of completion from this course is not a license.

BEFORE EVERY FADE LESSON

☐ Clippers cleaned, oiled and blades aligned

☐ Combs and guards disinfected and dry

☐ Hands washed, workstation wiped down

☐ Cape and neck strip fitted, client comfortable

☐ Good light on the head and a mirror to check both sides

About the video lessons

This module lists 36 curated public video lessons from experienced barbers, linked from their original channels. They belong to their creators and links can change over time. Every technique also has complete written steps, so you can follow it without the videos.

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1. Fade techniques overview

> *Understand the main fade families and the overall order of work before you start cutting.*

Estimated practice time: 20 to 30 minutes reading and planning, plus 45 minutes practice

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guard set (#0 to #4)
- Fine-tooth comb
- Spray bottle with water
- Trimmer
- Cape and neck strip

Step by step

1. Learn the four fade families by where the shortest hair ends: low (just above the ear and neckline), mid (about at the temple height), high (above the temple, near the parietal ridge) and skin or bald (blended down to bare skin).
2. Locate the three height markers on the head: the ear and nape, the temple line, and the parietal ridge, which is the point where the side of the head curves into the top.
3. Plan the fade line on the dry, combed hair: mark with the comb where the shortest section will end and where the blend will reach the longer hair.
4. Set a base length. For a skin fade use the clipper with no guard (or the #0 blade setting). For a shadow fade start with a #1 guard (1/8 in).
5. Cut the bottom section first at the shortest length, going up to your lowest line and keeping the clipper moving.
6. Step up one guard at a time (#1 to #2 to #3) and work upward in smaller and smaller bands, so each band overlaps the one before.
7. Blend the bands with the lever or with clipper-over-comb until no line is visible, then check with the mirror from the side and the back.
8. Finish the top and detail the edges, then compare both sides for balance.

Common mistakes

- Starting without a visual plan, so the fade line ends at a different height on each side
- Jumping more than one guard size at a time, which leaves a hard line
- Pushing the clipper into the skin instead of letting the guard glide over it
- Working on wet hair, which hides the true length and makes the blend look different once it dries

Practice drill

On a mannequin, draw the three height markers with a washable marker, then cut a simple #1 to #3 fade and check each band against your marks. Repeat three times until the bands match on both sides.

Safety note

Disinfect clippers, guards and combs between clients and check that blades are clean and aligned. Use a fresh neck strip every time. If you nick the skin, stop, put on gloves, apply light pressure with a clean gauze, and use a disposable antiseptic. Check your local licensing requirements before cutting hair for pay.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
HOW TO FADE FOR BEGINNERS Barber tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jbLTeJkDD1o	Barbing School Of Learning - Lameto	Beginner-friendly walkthrough of the core fade sequence from guidelines to blending.
How to Cut the Perfect Fade Haircut | Step-by-Step Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fMQciDwReKk	Stylist Elnar	Step-by-step fade cut showing setup, guard progression and finishing checks.
How to Cut a Fade Haircut Step-by-Step | Barber Techniques https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8BEzAsKbMJk	Stylist Elnar	Full fade routine covering low, medium and high variations side by side.

2. Understanding the 3 fade tones (dark, medium, light)

> *Recognize and control the three fade tones, which describe how much of the skin shows through the fade at the bottom.*

Estimated practice time: 45 minutes

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #0 to #3
- Fine-tooth comb
- Mannequin head or practice hair
- Mirror

Step by step

1. Define the tones. A dark fade keeps the hair thick and dark near the bottom, usually starting at a #2 guard (1/4 in) or #1 (1/8 in). A medium fade shows some scalp, starting around #1 or the closed blade. A light fade goes down to skin, starting at the bare blade.
2. Choose the tone with the client by looking at hair density, scalp color and how much contrast they want. A dark tone is gentler and grows out more slowly.
3. For a dark fade, start at the bottom with a #2 guard (1/4 in) around the nape and ear, then blend upward to #3 (3/8 in) and #4 (1/2 in).

4. For a medium fade, start with a #1 guard (1/8 in) at the bottom, then #2 (1/4 in), then #3 (3/8 in), keeping each band about 1/2 in to 1 in tall.
5. For a light fade, start with the clipper no guard or #0 (1/16 in) at the bottom, then #1 (1/8 in), then #2 (1/4 in), with narrower bands because the contrast is stronger.
6. Lock the starting point. Whatever tone you choose, mark the lowest cut line first and do not let the shortest guard go above it.
7. Blend upward with the lever or clipper-over-comb so the tone transitions smoothly into the top length.
8. Compare the finished tone to your plan from a few feet back and in the mirror, then adjust the lowest band if the tone is too light or too dark.

Common mistakes

- Using the wrong starting guard for the tone the client asked for
- Making the bands too tall on a light fade, which shows the blend as stripes
- Forgetting that dense, dark hair looks darker at the same guard than fine hair
- Changing the starting point partway through, so the tone no longer matches on both sides

Practice drill

Cut three small test patches on practice hair, one for each tone, side by side with the same width. Label each guard sequence and compare the contrast.

> **Safety note**
>
> On lighter fades, take extra care with the bare blade or #0 guard around the ear and nape, where the skin is thin. Keep the skin taut and use light pressure. Never use a dull or dirty blade, because it pulls and irritates the skin.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How To Fade with ONLY 3 Guards | Barber's Impact https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2IkBtCTphOw	Dave Cutz Hair	Building a fade with only three guards to see light, mid and dark tones.
How to do a Shadow Fade - EASY Barber TUTORIAL for begginners https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=25Y0LMu0MnI	David Falla	Shadow fade for beginners: how the soft tonal gradient is created.
STOP Messing Up Light/Shadow Fades (Barber Tutorial) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yHUz8vY8mUs	ROBERTO CROWN	Common mistakes when blending light and shadow tones, and how to avoid them.

3. Understanding recession lines

> *Read the hairline and the recession lines of the head so the fade starts and ends in the right place.*

Estimated practice time: 30 to 40 minutes

Tools you need

- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Washable marker (practice head)
- Mirror
- Cape and neck strip

Step by step

1. Identify the recession lines. They are the natural lines where the hair thins or ends: the front hairline, the temple recession, and the line behind the ear and at the nape. These lines guide where your fade starts.
2. Check for symmetry by standing behind the client and comparing the left and right temples in the mirror. Few heads are perfectly even, so note any difference now.
3. Find the temple point with the comb: sweep the hair back and see where the hairline turns and the sideburn begins.
4. Decide the fade height. A low fade starts just above the ear (about 1 in to 1 1/2 in above it). A mid fade starts around the temple. A high fade starts near the parietal ridge.
5. Map the line lightly with the comb and your finger, and mark it on a practice head with a washable marker.
6. Keep the recession line natural. Do not push the line higher than the client's temple or cut into the hairline unless they ask for a shape-up.
7. If one side recedes more, compensate by adjusting the starting height slightly rather than forcing both sides to the same number.
8. Check the line from the front, the side and the back before you blend. Correct any difference now, because it is much harder to fix after blending.

Common mistakes

- Ignoring a lopsided recession and cutting both sides to the same height
- Cutting the temple point too deep, which makes the hairline look cut back
- Marking the line too high, so the fade looks like a shelf
- Not checking the line from the back, where errors are hardest to see

Practice drill

On a practice head, draw the recession lines with a marker on both sides, then cut a #2 guard (1/4 in) bulk to those lines. Compare symmetry with a ruler or by photographing both sides.

> **Safety note**
>
> When working near the temple and sideburn, keep the skin tight with your free hand and use the trimmer corners gently. Avoid pressure on the temple area. Keep your client's head still and ask them to tell you if they feel any pinching.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
What to Tell Your Barber So He Doesn't Push Your Hairline Back https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=72iZnknW46U	Barber Style Directory	How hairline placement is judged so the line is not pushed back unnecessarily.
How to Hide Recession in Your Hair Line https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=P04pS4yQiNQ	Kayley Melissa	Styling and cutting approaches that soften visible recession at the hairline.
HOW TO DO A HAIRLINE | HAIRCUT TUTORIAL | #barber #hairtutorial #fade https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_5dg9NzbiME	Vonkeith The Artist	Shaping a clean natural hairline and reading where the line should sit.

4. Low fade

> *Cut a clean low fade, where the shortest hair stays low around the ear and the nape.*

Estimated practice time: 25 to 35 minutes per fade

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #1 to #4 (1/8 in to 1/2 in)
- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Spray bottle
- Mirror

Step by step

1. Section the hair. Comb the top up and out of the way and clip it if needed. Keep the sides and back clear.
2. Mark the low fade line about 1 in to 1 1/2 in above the ear, curving down behind the ear to the nape. This is the highest point of the shortest section.
3. With a #1 guard (1/8 in), cut from the nape up to the line, using a scooping motion that flicks away from the head at the top of the stroke.
4. Without moving the line, switch to a #2 guard (1/4 in) and cut from just below your first line up to about the ear height plus 1 in, again flicking out.
5. Switch to a #3 guard (3/8 in) and cut another 1 in band, overlapping the #2 band by about 1/4 in.

6. Blend the lines. Use the clipper with the lever open slightly and rock the blade in and out, or use clipper-over-comb along the transitions.
7. Repeat the process on the other side, keeping the heights equal by checking against the ear and the first line.
8. Check with the comb: if you can still see a line, use a #1 guard (1/8 in) lightly on the bottom or a #2 (1/4 in) over the line to soften it.
9. Finish by cleaning the neckline and around the ear with the trimmer, then brush the hair off.

Common mistakes

- Making the first line too high, so the fade becomes a mid fade by accident
- Letting the flick start too late, which leaves a hard shelf
- Skipping the mirror check on the back and the second side
- Blending with too much pressure, which pushes the clipper into the skin and creates a dark patch

Practice drill

Cut 5 low fades on a mannequin, using the same starting line each time. Aim for the finished blend to be invisible in a photo at arm's length.

> **Safety note**
>
> Keep the clipper blade flat and the skin taut near the nape and behind the ear. Fresh guards and a disinfected clipper reduce the risk of skin irritation. If a client has a mole, scar or skin condition, avoid cutting over it and ask them to point out sensitive areas first.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to do a LOW FADE Haircut! (Step-by-Step Tutorial) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=QNdSMspFw1g	Nevin The Barber	Complete low fade: clipper setup, canvas, reference points, weight removal, corners.
Low Fade Haircut in 4 Minutes (Full Step-by-Step Guide) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fGJRYDraoUI	Stylist Elnar	Fast four-minute low fade with the full sequence shown clearly.
Low Fade Haircut Tutorial: Step-by-Step Guide for Barbers https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=e92AIT4rFtI	House of Shaves Barbershop	Low fade in a barbershop setting with tools and process explained.

5. Mid fade

> *Cut a mid fade, where the shortest hair ends around the temple height and the blend sits in the middle of the sides.*

Estimated practice time: 30 to 40 minutes per fade

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #0 to #4
- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Spray bottle
- Mirror

Step by step

1. Comb the hair up and sectioning off the top. Check the temple and the parietal ridge so you know your boundaries.
2. Mark the mid fade line at the temple height, which is roughly 2 in to 2 1/2 in above the ear, curving gently around the head.
3. Cut the bottom with a #1 guard (1/8 in) or the closed blade, from the neckline up to the mark, using an upward flicking motion.
4. Switch to a #2 guard (1/4 in) and cut from just below the first line to about 1 in above it, moving at a steady speed.
5. Switch to a #3 guard (3/8 in) and cut another band up to the transition point, which should land just under the parietal ridge.
6. Blend the area using the lever or clipper-over-comb. Pay attention to the area just above the first line, where most lines appear.
7. Match the other side by using the same marks and the same number of guard sizes. Check both sides in the mirror from the front.
8. Check the blend with the comb pulling the hair gently out: any dark or light stripes mean you need more blending in that area.
9. Detail the edges and the neckline, then refine any spots that are lighter or darker than the rest.

Common mistakes

- Placing the line too high, which turns the mid fade into a high fade
- Treating the temple as a flat spot and cutting the bands in a straight line instead of following the head
- Using the wrong guard sequence, creating an uneven blend
- Rushing the blending step and leaving lines at the second guard

Practice drill

On a mannequin, cut a mid fade and mark the transition lines before you blend. Then blend and compare how many marks remain. Aim to reduce them to none in three attempts.

> **Safety note**
>
> Work at a comfortable height so you do not strain your wrist. Keep the blade flat to the skin, and stop if the client reports heat from the blade. Oil and clean the clipper regularly because hot blades irritate skin.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How To Do a Mid Fade for Beginners | Step-by-Step Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xWv1yYtF_4Q	FADED CULTURE	Mid fade from start to finish, including the thinking behind each stage.
How to Cut a Perfect Mid Fade | Step-by-Step Barber Tutorial for Beginners https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K_RFiOif9No	High Universal Cutz	Clean mid fade for beginners with clear guard and clipper placement.
Mid Skin Fade Tutorial - Barbering https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Bip5Xtm7nAg	Mike Taylor Education	Detailed mid skin fade from an educator, with clipper-work explanation.

6. High fade

> *Cut a high fade, where the shortest hair rises close to the parietal ridge for a bold, defined look.*

Estimated practice time: 35 to 45 minutes per fade

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #0 to #4
- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Spray bottle
- Mirror

Step by step

1. Section the top and find the parietal ridge by pressing your hand on the side of the head: the point where the surface turns from vertical to horizontal is the ridge.
2. Mark the high fade line just below the ridge, usually about 3 in to 3 1/2 in above the ear, following the curve of the head.
3. Start at the bottom with the closed blade or a #0 guard (1/16 in) up to a line around 1 1/2 in above the ear.
4. Switch to a #1 guard (1/8 in) and cut the next band up about 1 in to 1 1/2 in, using a flicking motion at the end of each stroke.
5. Switch to a #2 guard (1/4 in) and cut the next band, leaving a thin gap of about 1/2 in to blend later.

6. Use a #3 guard (3/8 in) for the transition into the longer hair at the top, bringing it close to the parietal ridge.
7. Blend the lines with the lever open and a rocking motion, or clipper-over-comb, working in small sections and checking often.
8. Repeat on the other side, using the same ridge marks, and compare both sides from the back with the mirror.
9. Finish with a trimmer line-up around the hairline and clean the neckline if requested.

Common mistakes

- Cutting the fade line above the ridge, where the hair turns and the fade looks floating
- Cutting the transition too fast, creating a visible line between #1 and #2
- Forgetting that high fades show every mistake and need extra blending time
- Using too much pressure on the temple and cutting the hair too short

Practice drill

Cut two high fades on the mannequin, one with the bare blade at the bottom and one starting at #1 (1/8 in). Compare how the light fade shows more contrast.

> **Safety note**
>
> High fades expose more skin, so check for sunburn, irritation or skin conditions before you start. Do not clip over scabs or lesions. Keep the clipper blade clean and cool, and use a clean towel or neck strip to reduce itching.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
High Fade Haircut Tutorial | Step by Step Barber Guide for Beginners & Pros https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=1HfLPv5CJ4A	High Universal Cutz	High fade step by step, suited to beginners and working barbers.
HIGH FADE BEGINNER BARBER TUTORIAL https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=f_rIQ0IBgFg	Barber Style Directory	Beginner high fade, including guidelines and keeping the lineup straight.
Blurry High Bald Fade | Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=toHoTf4PJ1Q	Nevin The Barber	High bald fade: setting the canvas, reference points and removing weight.

7. Skin (bald) fade

> *Cut a skin fade, where the hair blends all the way down to bare skin at the bottom.*

Estimated practice time: 40 to 50 minutes per fade

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Foil shaver or trimmer (for finishing)
- Guards #1 to #4
- Fine-tooth comb
- Spray bottle
- Mirror
- Gloves

Step by step

1. Prepare the skin. Wipe it clean and make sure it is dry. Check for scars, moles, irritation or razor bumps before you start.
2. Choose the fade height (low, mid or high) and mark the line where the skin ends and the first band begins.
3. Cut the bottom with the clipper with no guard (closed blade) up to the first line. Move with the grain and keep the blade flat.
4. Blend up with a #0 guard (1/16 in) or the slightly open lever, overlapping the skin section by about 1/4 in.
5. Continue with a #1 guard (1/8 in) and then a #2 (1/4 in), working in narrow bands about 1/2 in to 1 in tall.
6. Use the lever to soften the transition at each step. Move the blade slowly and keep the flick consistent.
7. Finish with a foil shaver or trimmer on the skin area for a smooth look. Use light pressure and do not repeat on the same spot.
8. Check the blend from the side and the back. Any dark patches or hard lines show up more on bare skin than on longer hair.
9. Apply a soothing, fragrance-free aftershave or balm if the client likes it, and remind them to avoid scratching the area.

Common mistakes

- Pressing the bare blade too hard and causing clipper burn
- Starting the blend too high, which makes the skin area look like a patch
- Cutting skin fades on clients with sensitive skin without a patch test
- Not cleaning and oiling the blade, which gets hot and irritates skin

Practice drill

On a mannequin, practice the transition between bare blade and #1 guard (1/8 in) 10 times. Focus on the flick motion and a clean overlap.

> **Safety note**
>
> Wear gloves if the client has any skin condition, and never use a blade on irritated or broken skin. Use a clean, disinfected blade. Stop if the skin turns red or the client feels burning. Single-use razors only, if you finish with a razor, and dispose of them in a sharps container. Cuts: apply pressure with clean gauze and an antiseptic, and follow your local rules for bloodborne exposure.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Step By Step Skin Fade Haircut | How To Tutorial Beginners Guide https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=yUdTXSFIUR0	Its Kieron Price	Full skin fade shown in real time for beginner barbers.
HOW TO DO A PERFECT SKIN FADE | Full Step-by-Step Barber Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gd6ZCi5qA0U	Yass The Barber	Skin fade breakdown covering clipper work, blending and finishing.
High Skin Fade Haircut Step By Step Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xFC3WudaPhg	House of Shaves Barbershop	High skin fade in a shop, starting with scooping bulk away.

8. Taper fade intro

> *Learn the taper fade, a subtler fade that gradually shortens the hair around the ears and neckline while keeping the sides longer.*

Estimated practice time: 25 to 35 minutes

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #1 to #4
- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Scissors
- Spray bottle

Step by step

1. Understand the difference: a taper fade only blends the edges (sideburns, neckline and around the ear), while a regular fade blends the whole side of the head.
2. Decide the length of the sides with the client. Common sides are #3 (3/8 in) or #4 (1/2 in) for a classic taper.
3. Cut the sides to the base length first with the chosen guard, moving from the bottom up and flicking out at the top.
4. Mark the taper area: about 1 in to 1 1/2 in around the ear and along the neckline.

5. Use a #2 guard (1/4 in) in the taper area, from the edge up, to start the shortening.
6. Use a #1 guard (1/8 in) at the very edge and blend upward into the base length with the lever or clipper-over-comb.
7. Check the sideburn. It should taper evenly from the longer sides to the shorter edge. Use a trimmer to tidy the line if needed.
8. Repeat on the other side, and compare both sides for length and shape.
9. Clean up the neckline with a trimmer, rounding it, squaring it or tapering it depending on the client's preference.

Common mistakes

- Taking the taper too high, which turns it into a regular low fade
- Leaving a hard line where the taper meets the base length
- Cutting the sideburns uneven in length
- Using the trimmer to blend instead of the clipper, which creates uneven lines

Practice drill

Cut a classic taper on the mannequin with #3 sides (3/8 in) and a #1 edge (1/8 in). Then repeat with #4 sides (1/2 in) and compare.

> **Safety note**
>
> The ear is delicate. Fold it forward with your free hand and keep the blade or trimmer away from the cartilage. Use the trimmer with the guard on for the first pass. If the client moves suddenly, stop and reset.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
How to Taper: Beginners Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=uXLfhUp4U54	Hot Heads Media	Taper basics for beginners: where the taper sits and how to cut it.
How to Do a Taper Fade | Barber Tutorial for Beginners & Pros https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vEs9pBF8r4g	Yass The Barber	Clean taper fade process for newer and experienced barbers.
Mid Taper Fade Tutorial (Step-by-Step for Beginners) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=l8yjj7r_xp4	ChunkyCutz	Mid taper fade explained simply, step by step for beginners.

9. Blending with the clipper lever and clipper-over-comb

> *Master the two main blending techniques so you can erase lines between guard sizes.*

Estimated practice time: 45 to 60 minutes

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers with lever
- Fine-tooth comb
- Guards #1 to #3
- Spray bottle
- Mirror

Step by step

1. Lever blending: set the lever closed, make a pass, then open the lever slightly and make another pass in the same area. Repeat with each slight opening to feather the line.
2. Start at the bottom of the line with the lever closed and move upward, flicking the clipper away from the head at the end of each stroke.
3. Keep the stroke length short, about 2 in to 3 in, and overlap each stroke by about half to avoid new lines.
4. Clipper-over-comb: hold the comb flat against the head with the teeth pointing up, so the hair comes through the teeth.
5. Run the clipper over the comb from the bottom up, cutting the hair that sticks out above the comb, and move the comb away from the head as you go to lengthen the hair gradually.
6. Use the lever open for the upper part of the blend and closed for the lower part, so the shortest hair stays short.
7. Check the area by combing the hair out in different directions. If you see a light or dark band, go back over that area with a light lever pass.
8. Alternate between the two methods in difficult areas, such as the curve above the ear, where the head changes shape.
9. Do a final pass with no guard and light pressure to smooth the blend, but only if it is needed.

Common mistakes

- Using the same lever setting for the whole blend
- Holding the comb too far from the head and cutting too much hair
- Cutting against the grain with the blade tilted, which leaves marks
- Moving too fast, so the clipper cannot cut evenly

Practice drill

Draw a hard line on the mannequin with a #1 guard (1/8 in) and a #3 guard (3/8 in). Blend it out using only the lever, then repeat with clipper-over-comb. Compare which was faster and cleaner.

> **Safety note**
>
> Hold the comb steady and keep your fingers out of the blade path. A sharp, clean blade is safer than a dull one because it needs less pressure. Disinfect the comb between clients, and replace any with broken teeth.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Clipper Over Comb Tips for Seamless Blends https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vmEQCvQ3NCI	Eighty20 Barber Academy	Two clipper-over-comb blend variations for seamless transitions.
Clipper Over Comb Technique Beginner Barber's Guide https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cZYD5Yhs0YI	House of Shaves Barbershop	Clipper-over-comb fundamentals for beginner barbers, including comb angle and movement.
HOW TO FADE!! (Understanding clipper levers and guards) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iNy_T39sgIE	Fade Nicegood	How clipper levers and guards combine to create fade blending.

10. The Clean Fade (removing every blend mark)

> *Finish a fade so there are no visible lines, patches or streaks from any angle.*

Estimated practice time: 20 to 30 minutes

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #0 to #3
- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Detailing brush
- Mirror
- Good lighting

Step by step

1. Stop and inspect. After the main cutting, comb the hair flat and look at the fade from the front, the side and the back, in good light.
2. Find the blend marks by running your hand over the fade. Darker or lighter bands, or places where your fingers feel a step, are lines.
3. Fix lines with the lever open slightly. Run the clipper in small upward strokes along the line, flicking away.

4. For stubborn lines, use clipper-over-comb across the line, with the comb held flat and moving upward.
5. Check dark patches. They usually mean the hair is too long at that spot. Take the same guard that was used below it and do a light pass.
6. Check light patches. They usually mean the hair is too short at that spot. You cannot add hair back, so blend the surrounding area to match.
7. Compare left and right by checking from the back with a hand mirror. Fix any difference in height or tone.
8. Brush away loose hair, and re-check. Loose hair can hide marks.
9. Finish with the trimmer on the edges and apply a light styling product if requested.

Common mistakes

- Calling it done without inspecting from all angles
- Overworking one spot and making it too short
- Ignoring lighting, so lines only show in the daylight after the client leaves
- Blending only the front and neglecting the back

Practice drill

Cut a fade on a mannequin and deliberately leave 3 lines. Then find and fix them with the lever and clipper-over-comb. Repeat until you can fix all three in under 5 minutes.

> **Safety note**
>
> Fine inspection means close work. Keep the clipper off the skin while you check, and switch it off if you need to use both hands. Do not use a razor to fix marks unless you are licensed and trained. Clean hair clippings from the skin to prevent irritation.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
5 Ways to remove Bald Line (Tutorial) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cSHXXFsexn0	ConcisetheBarber	Five methods to erase the bald line, some easy for beginners.
HOW TO ERASE THE BALD LINE | STEP BY STEP #3 BALD FADE | BEGINNING BARBER TUTORIAL https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jUAqEkXR9oA	David Escamilla	Step-by-step method to erase the bald line in a bald fade.
Use blade cornering to remove lines and larks in short fade clipper haircuts https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=htOBRIFhjmo	ivan zoot	Blade cornering technique to remove lines and marks in short fades.

11. Fading around the ear and neckline

> *Blend the fade cleanly around the ear and finish a neat neckline.*

Estimated practice time: 20 to 30 minutes

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Trimmer
- Guards #1 to #3
- Fine-tooth comb
- Detailing brush
- Mirror

Step by step

1. Fold the ear forward gently with your free hand. This exposes the area behind the ear and keeps the ear away from the blade.
2. Use the trimmer or the clipper with the lever closed to cut the hair behind the ear, moving in short strokes from the bottom upward.
3. Cut the hair above the ear with a #1 guard (1/8 in) and blend upward into the #2 (1/4 in) and #3 (3/8 in) areas.
4. Fold the ear down and trim the front of the ear, taking care around the tragus (the small flap in front of the ear canal).
5. Decide the neckline shape with the client: natural, rounded, squared or tapered. Mark it with the comb.
6. Cut the neckline with the trimmer, working from the center to each side with the blade pointing slightly outward.
7. Blend the lower hair above the neckline into the fade with the lever, using small upward strokes.
8. Check both ears and the back of the neck from behind and from the sides. They should be symmetrical.
9. Brush off the hair and clean up any remaining stray hairs with the trimmer corner.

Common mistakes

- Cutting too close to the ear and nicking the cartilage
- Making the neckline too high, which looks unnatural when the hair grows
- Letting the neckline be uneven because you did not center it
- Skipping the fold on the ear and leaving a chunk of hair behind

Practice drill

On a mannequin, practice squared, rounded and tapered necklines, 3 times each. Photograph the results and check symmetry.

> **Safety note**
>
> The ear and nape are sensitive. Always protect the ear with your free hand, and keep trimmer blades sharp and clean. If you accidentally cut the skin, stop, put on gloves, apply pressure with clean gauze, and use a disposable antiseptic or styptic as local rules allow. Dispose of any contaminated material properly.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Haircut Tutorial | How to trim around ears and neckline at home https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=gL_9X1AMFX0	House of Shaves Barbershop	Trimming around the ears and neckline in clear steps.
How To Do A Neck Taper | Neck Taper Fade Tutorial https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=7AgVScdXEFA	EZBLADESHAVINGPRODUCTS	Neck taper demonstration with step-by-step clipper and outliner work.
How To Trim Neckline And Around Ears Between Haircuts https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ksTJqTGazOo	House of Shaves Barbershop	Keeping the neckline and ear area clean between full haircuts.

12. Fade troubleshooting (lines, patches, uneven sides)

> *Diagnose and correct the most common fade problems quickly and safely.*

Estimated practice time: 20 to 40 minutes

Tools you need

- Adjustable clippers
- Guards #1 to #3
- Fine-tooth comb
- Trimmer
- Mirror
- Good lighting

Step by step

1. Diagnose before you cut. Look at the fade in good light and decide whether the problem is a line, a patch or an uneven side.
2. For a line (a visible step between two lengths): use the lever open slightly and make small upward flicking strokes along the line.
3. For a stubborn line: switch to clipper-over-comb. Hold the comb flat and run the clipper over it, moving up and away from the head.

4. For a dark patch (hair too long): take the same guard as the surrounding area and do a light pass, moving up from the patch.
5. For a light patch (hair too short): blend the surrounding area down to the same length, using the lever closed, until the patch no longer stands out.
6. For uneven sides: compare the height of the fade line on both sides with the comb. Raise the lower side only if it can be done by shortening the longer hair.
7. Check the symmetry of the ears, the temples and the neckline from the back, in the mirror.
8. Recheck after each fix. Do not move on until you can no longer see the problem from arm's length.
9. If a fix would make the fade too short, stop and talk to the client about a shorter style or a neater finish.

Common mistakes

- Fixing a line by cutting the whole area again, which can make it worse
- Chasing perfection and cutting too much hair
- Ignoring the client's head shape, scars or cowlicks
- Not asking the client to look in the mirror and confirm they are happy

Practice drill

On a mannequin, create a line, a dark patch, a light patch and an uneven side on purpose. Fix each one, in order, and time yourself.

> **Safety note**
>
> When correcting, slow down. Rushed fixes cause nicks and clipper burn. Re-disinfect any tools you drop or set down on a dirty surface. If a client reports irritation, stop, remove the clippers from the skin and let them check in the mirror. Check your local licensing requirements and do not perform services beyond your training.

Curated video lessons

VIDEO LESSON	CHANNEL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Why Your Fades Look Bad: 7 Beginner Mistakes Revealed https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YVgmguQ5TjM	Barber Style Directory	Seven beginner mistakes that make fades look bad, and the fixes.
Barber Tutorial: How To Fix a Men's Haircut (Low Fade) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AcfKKyHevWE	MC Barber	Correcting a low fade that was cut incorrectly, working from the back.
Fixing a Bad Haircut: Expert Tips & Tricks by MC Barber https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dOQErhJ5nEM	MC Barber	Practical methods for repairing an under-faded or over-faded haircut.

Next step

Practice each technique on a mannequin head until you can repeat it with clean results, then move to the next module.